# The Shopify Store Launch Bible

GPLMart - practical digital resources for ecommerce sellers, developers and creators.

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# The Shopify Store Launch Bible

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## Chapter 1 - The launch mindset (read this first)

### What "launch" actually means

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### The 80/20 of launching

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80% of launch success = product choice + trust signals + traffic
20% = theme design, apps, fancy features


A basic Dawn theme with great products and real reviews beats a custom-designed store
with blurry supplier photos every time.

### India-specific reality check

- **COD is not optional** for most Indian categories - 40-60% of orders are COD
depending on category
- **RTO (return to origin)** will eat 15-30% of COD orders initially - budget for it
- **WhatsApp is your sales channel** - order updates, tracking, support all happen there
- **Trust signals matter more** - Indian buyers check ratings, reviews and "is this
legit" harder than US buyers

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## Chapter 2 - Pre-launch: the 7 decisions before you touch Shopify

Do NOT sign up for Shopify until these are answered:

### 1. What are you selling?

Not "ecommerce products" - a specific product or tight category. "Phone accessories for
Android users" beats "gadgets". Focus wins.

### 2. Who is buying it?
```

Age, city/tier, income, where they hang out online, what problem your product solves for them. Write it down in one paragraph.

### 3. What's your price range?

Impulse ( ¹199-499), mid ( ¹500-1999), premium ( ¹2000+). Your price decides your photography, your ad channel and your margin math.

### 4. Where will traffic come from?

Pick ONE primary channel for launch: Instagram reels, WhatsApp status, Facebook ads, or SEO content. You can add channels later - you cannot do all at once.

### 5. Can you fulfil orders?

Dropshipping supplier lead time? Your own stock? Pre-orders? Know the real delivery window - it goes on your product pages and in customer messages.

### 6. What's your margin after everything?

```
Real margin = Price - Product cost - Shipping - Payment fees - Returns/RTO reserve
```

If real margin is under 25%, your pricing or product choice needs work before launch.

### 7. What makes you trustworthy?

GST number, business address, return policy, real photos, WhatsApp number, response time. Collect these BEFORE launch - adding them after is painful.

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## Chapter 3 - Store setup: the 5 essentials (skip everything else)

### 1. Theme: Dawn or a Dawn-child

Free, fast, supported forever. Customize colors/fonts to your brand. Do NOT buy a ¹15,000 theme on day 1 - you don't know what you need yet.

### 2. Payments: Razorpay + COD

- Razorpay for UPI/cards/netbanking (instant activation for most Indian businesses)
- COD for categories where it's expected (fashion, home, general merchandise)
- Test both with a real ¹1 transaction before launch

### 3. Shipping: one courier to start

Delhivery, Bluedart or Shiprocket aggregator. Shiprocket is easiest for multi-courier rate comparison. Set realistic delivery promises - under-promise, over-deliver.

### 4. WhatsApp Business app

Free, on your phone. Set up: business name, catalogue, quick replies ("Where is my order?", "Return policy"), greeting message. This is your command center.

### 5. Policies: 4 pages that build trust

- Refund/return policy (7-15 days, clear conditions)
- Shipping policy (timeframes, charges)
- Privacy policy (required for payment gateways)
- Contact page with real WhatsApp number + email + address

Everything else - loyalty apps, popups, chat widgets, fancy countdown timers - comes AFTER first sales.

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## Chapter 4 - Products: the listing that actually sells

### Product selection for launch

- Start with 5-15 products max - a focused store beats a 500-product mess
- Choose products you can photograph or that have decent supplier images
- Verify supplier reliability BEFORE listing (order a sample to yourself - always)

### The listing formula

```
Title: [Brand] [Product type] [key spec] [use case]
Photos: 5-8 images - hero shot, angles, detail macro, size reference, lifestyle
Price: psychological ( ¹499 not  ¹500) with real margin
Bullets: 5 benefit-led points (see the Product Listing Copy Bible approach)
Description: problem !’ solution !’ specs !’ FAQ
```

### Photos: the #1 conversion factor

- Supplier images are usually terrible - watermarked, cluttered, low-res
- Minimum viable: clean white-background shots. AI photoshoot tools or a  ¹500 photo setup (white sheet + daylight) works
- Video: 10-second product video on hero products lifts conversion noticeably

### Pricing your first products

```
Price = (Product cost + Shipping + Fees) / (1 - Target margin)
Example:  ¹300 product +  ¹80 shipping + 2% fees, 40% margin target
Price = (300 + 80 + ~10) / 0.6 "H  ¹650 !’ round to  ¹649 or  ¹699
```

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## Chapter 5 - The launch traffic plan (week by week)

### Week -1: Tease

- Announce on WhatsApp status, Instagram, personal network
- "Something new launching this week" - collect interest
- Finalize products, test checkout end-to-end

### Week 0: Launch day

- Email/WhatsApp broadcast to every contact you have
- Instagram: launch reel + stories + feed post
- Offer: launch discount or free shipping - real, time-bound
- Be online all day - answer every WhatsApp message fast

### Week 1: Momentum

- Post daily: product spotlights, unboxing, behind-scenes
- WhatsApp status: new products, offers, packing orders
- Reply to EVERY comment and DM within an hour
- First 10 orders: personally thank each customer, ask for review/photo

### Week 2-4: Optimize

- Check: which products get views but no sales? (price/photo/listing problem)
- Which products sell without promotion? (double down - ads, bundles)
- Fix the leaks: slow pages, broken links, unanswered messages

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## Chapter 6 - Fulfilment: don't let operations kill you

### The daily routine

- Morning: check orders, print shipping labels, hand to courier
- Throughout day: WhatsApp replies (order updates, tracking, support)
- Evening: confirm dispatches, update customers

### WhatsApp order flow (the Indian standard)

```
Order placed !’ "Thanks! Order #[X] confirmed. We'll ship within 24h."
Shipped !’ "Your order is on the way! Track: [link]. Delivery in 3-5 days."
Out for delivery !’ optional but loved
Delivered !’ "Delivered! How's [product]? Reply with feedback - we'd love a review."
```

Automate with Shopify WhatsApp apps or do it manually at first - either way, customers expect updates.

### RTO management (COD reality)

- Confirm COD orders via WhatsApp/call before dispatch for high-value orders (> ¹1000)
- Address verification matters - incomplete addresses = RTO
- Expect 15-30% RTO initially; it drops as you build trust and repeat buyers

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## Chapter 7 - First 90 days: from launch to real business

### Days 1-30: survive and learn

- Goal: 10-50 orders, learn what sells, fix basics
- Do NOT add new products constantly - optimize what you have
- Collect every piece of feedback

### Days 31-60: double what works

- Pick your top 2-3 products by sales + margin
- Improve their listings (photos, copy, price tests)
- Start simple ads on proven winners only ( ¹300-500/day Meta ads test)
- Email/WhatsApp your first customers: "new arrivals + 10% off"

### Days 61-90: systemize

- Bundle your bestsellers (raises order value)
- Ask every happy customer for review/photo - build social proof
- Document your supplier lead times, best courier, top products
- Plan next quarter: more products? new channel? hire help?

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## Chapter 8 - The launch checklist (print this)

PRE-LAUNCH
[ ] Products chosen (5-15, focused category)
[ ] Supplier sample ordered and tested
[ ] Shopify store live with Dawn theme customized
[ ] Razorpay activated + tested with real payment
[ ] COD enabled (if category needs it)
[ ] Shipping courier set up + rates tested
[ ] WhatsApp Business set up with catalogue
[ ] Policies published (refund, shipping, privacy, contact)
[ ] Product photos ready (5+ per product, clean)
[ ] Prices set with real margin math
[ ] Checkout tested end-to-end (all payment methods)
[ ] Order notification emails working

LAUNCH WEEK
[ ] WhatsApp status announcement
[ ] Instagram launch content posted
[ ] Personal network informed
[ ] Launch offer live (discount/free shipping)
[ ] Online all day for customer messages
[ ] First orders personally thanked

POST-LAUNCH
[ ] Daily WhatsApp order updates going out
[ ] Reviews requested from happy customers
[ ] Weekly sales review (what sells, what's stuck)
[ ] Winning products identified for ads

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## Chapter 9 - Common launch mistakes (and the fix)

| Mistake | Why it kills you | Fix |
|---|---|---|
| 500 products on day 1 | Nothing stands out, photos are bad, support drowns | Launch with 5-15 focused products |
| No COD when customers expect it | Lost 40-60% of orders | Enable COD for relevant categories |

| Supplier images unedited | Looks fake/untrustworthy | Clean photos minimum, AI photoshoot better |
| No WhatsApp updates | Customers panic, chargebacks, bad reviews | Automate order status messages |
| Ads before organic proof | Paying to send traffic to unproven store | Get 10-20 organic orders first |
| Fake urgency everywhere | Countdown timers that reset = distrust | Real deadlines only |
| No return policy clarity | Disputes, bad reviews, payment gateway issues | Clear published policy |
| Underpricing for "traction" | Margin death, can't afford ads | Price for 35-50% real margin |

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## Chapter 10 - Your first 90 days scoreboard

Track weekly:

- Orders count
- Revenue
- Top 3 products by units
- Return/RTO rate
- WhatsApp response time
- Review count

By day 90 you should know: what sells, what margin you actually make, which channel brings buyers, and whether this is a business or a hobby. Both answers are fine - but now you'll know which.

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